

Volcanoes

Volcanoes form when magma – a mixture of hot gas, ash, and melted rock – erupts from a crack in the Earth's surface. The melted rock, called lava, flows out and hardens. As layers of lava build up, the volcano gets bigger. A volcano can be active, dormant, or extinct.

! WOW!

Most of Earth's active volcanoes lie hidden from view, under the ocean!



STRATOVOLCANO
Mount Fuji, Japan

Stratovolcanoes are tall and cone-shaped, with steep sides. They are made up of lots of layers of lava and ash that have cooled and hardened. Their eruptions can be very powerful and dangerous.

Inside a volcano

When pressure in the magma chamber under a volcano gets too high, the magma is forced up and out of the main vent. This is called an eruption. The force of this eruption blows rock off the top of the volcano, creating a bowl-shaped hollow, called a crater. In some volcanoes, magma also erupts from smaller vents that branch out from the main vent.

